FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Political importance is always challenging to quantify, but Bihar will rank among the most significant recent victories for the National Democratic Alliance (NDA). Its magisterial sweep, with 202 seats in a 243-member assembly, gives it an 83 per cent footprint, higher than what it achieved in Maharashtra last year. How did the NDA pull off this massive mandate? In this week's cover package, Senior Editor Amitabh Srivastava gives us the inside story of the war room. It's a canvas bristling with detail about the NDA's awe-inspiring election management. It worked like a gigantic industrial complex. Or a symphony orchestra, with thousands of elements, all working at peak efficiency.

Fronting the charge was Modi himself, who went into turbo mode, addressing 14 rallies across Bihar, a state he had already visited seven times earlier in 2025. Then there was the indefatigable Amit Shah. The Union home minister camped in Bihar, forming the nerve-centre of the BJP war room, his algorithmic brain connecting the big picture with the countless minutiae that 243 assembly segments entail. From his base, mostly at Hotel Maurya in Patna but also in field camps in far-out districts like Purnea, he ensured that qualitative human intelligence went alongside abstract data crunching. With him were Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan, the BJP's Bihar in-charge, and party national secretary Vinod Tawde. They worked in tandem with Sanjay Jha, Janata Dal (United) working president, to ensure perfect coordination and smoothen the rough edges.

▲ Nov. 2, 2020

In the trio's 'no gap' micro-management, every booth mattered. The BJP had divided Bihar into five zones, each overseen by seniors from outside. They, in turn, fed off the groundwork laid by the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and its affiliates, which had long cultivated booth-level presence. This feedback mechanism alerted the BJP to the growing anti-incumbency mood as early as July. The NDA war room flagged the need to accelerate welfare spending. That's what led to the game-changing decision to roll out Rs 10,000 each to 15.1 million beneficiaries under a women's employment scheme. This direct benefit transfer proved to be a masterstroke: the money in their accounts became proof of delivery and a central rallying point to boost female voter turnout. Then came seat allocation: the BJP and JD(U) were prudently allotted 101 each; Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party (LJP), back with the NDA, was given 29. Candidate selection for every NDA constituent was guided by the BJP's computational skills. If a seat demanded a specific sub-caste, the candidate had to match that profile. The precision was surgical, the execution flawless.

Meanwhile, chief minister Nitish Kumar, defying rumours about failing health, proved that he enjoys immense cachet with the people. The BJP knew the JD(U) was a guarantor of its stability at the Centre. It was imperative that the source of stability itself be fortified. Hence, even if after some hesitation, the BJP wisely decided to put its own ambition on the back burner and backed a tenth term for Nitish, who played his own indispensability like the crafty politician that he is. The war room was also the first to read the signals about a mood change on the ground: Nitish's popularity was seeing a revival. Apparently, the very possibility of a change in incumbency, with young Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) chief Tejashwi Yadav poised as challenger, was swinging voters right back to Nitish. Around then, the BJP dispelled its initial ambiguity about Nitish being the CM's choice, with Shah asserting there is "no vacancy for the post of PM of India and CM of Bihar". That sealed the issue for many voters, yielding a victory whose significance extends beyond its borders. The NDA has now won four consecutive assembly elections after falling short of a majority in the 2024 general election. That gives the BJP a surge of momentum ahead of extremely crucial assembly elections in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Assam and Kerala.

The burden of power now awaits the NDA. It has plenty of promises to keep. Chief among these will be the pledge to top up the initial cash grant of Rs 10,000 to women with assistance of up to Rs 2 lakh for viable small enterprise ideas. Experts reckon these schemes may entail an unplanned outgo of up to Rs 40,000 crore in FY26 alone, nearly 4 per cent of Bihar's GSDP. Not far behind is the promise to generate 10 million jobs. To accomplish it, Bihar needs a full reboot. Given its legacy of poverty, it's gone unnoticed that Bihar has been one of India's fastest-growing economies. Yet its per capita income of Rs 69,321 remains only about a third of the national average. Over 34 per cent of families earn Rs 6,000 or less a month, and over half of households have at least one migrant. There's one answer to all the riddles: reviving a comatose industry. Only that can generate jobs within the state, stanch outmigration, break the growth ceiling, and move the focus of governance away from temporary relief to dignified employment.

Once the euphoria ebbs, Bihar will be back to the problems that bedevil this poor state. Elections, after all, are won with promises. Governance is tested by delivery. The NDA has secured an overwhelming majority. The people have spoken unequivocally. The bigger the mandate, the bigger the responsibility. Now it must justify that trust. No time for excuses. Only time for solutions and actions.

(Aroon Purie)